



the basic unit of political choice and of economic opportunity. Yet, electoral politics and market economics are working in different directions. The political dynamics are to a degree centripetal—pulling regional politics closer to Delhi by giving them a stake in the coalitional structure of power. The great economic disparity across the states, though, portends more centrifugal potentialities: rich and poor states will make different claims on the Centre and will, in turn, require asymmetric response, and inter-state rivalries over migration, environmental effects of development, and access to resources, both natural and fiscal, will rise.

In this circumstance, the need for an overarching national story, one that can frame the particularities of policies and outcomes, that can explain them and endow them with some larger purpose, is clear and urgent. The 2009 election hinted at a shift in favour of nationally

Dude Place, acrylic on canvas by Saladrh Sovani, Courtesy Religare Arts & Gallery



oriented parties. There is a genuine opening for a nationalism that can speak and listen to the multiplying self-definitions being produced by India's open society.

We will also need a rejuvenated nationalism to steer ourselves. India needs to be able to project a defined and positive sense of what it stands for in the world—a self-definition not designed expressly to please any particular power, yet equally one that doesn't simply revel in being a spoiler. Such a nationalism would give the much-needed ballast to definitions of our national interest, at present too narrowly specified in conventional security terms. India is entering an era of difficult, high-stake negotiations and bargains, like climate change, the terms of international trade, the management of financial regulation, the uncertainties of Asian power alignments and mounting regional dangers. Nationalism cannot alone suffice as a way of addressing such problems, and very often, in the form of economic protection-

ism or cultural chauvinism, it is the main obstacle to tackling them. But, sadly, it is probably a necessary starting point, an opening gambit, in a world where the wealthy and the powerful are increasingly bent on pulling up the draw-bridges and protecting what they have already acquired. No doubt, we need to work towards establishing more inclusive structures of international governance and collaboration, but we have also to be prepared to survive in a world in which such structures may fail or prove ineffective. We need also to anticipate the possibility that it is nationalism that may come to define the character of relations with our powerful Asian cohabitants.

In the face of such varied and complex challenges, the vapid and ineffectualness of Hindutva nationalism is clear. A more adequate national vision will have to draw on our founding principles: on, above all, a commitment to the value of diversity, both as collective feature of society as a whole, as well as an internal trait of the individual, enabling plural identities at both social and individual levels. The evidence, whether concerning biological development, societies in history, or individual psychology, shows that diversity best allows successful adaptation; it provides structural resilience,

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and is self-immunising. Narendra Modi's Gujarat is in India; but India is not his Gujarat.

We shall need to elaborate a nationalism that proceeds by composition, not by imposition; that is inductive and additive, not deductive and subtractive; that abandons the elusive search for essentialist identitarian criteria (land, ethnicity, religion, blood) and instead reaffirms our foundational political principles.

And this means a nationalism that is confident enough also to engage in fundamental debates about the Republic. Should we not be moving towards the goal of a common citizenship and a system civil law based on secular principles for all? Should we not be looking beyond reservations as the primary tool to handle the intricate problem of social justice? One can acknowledge that the BJP was right to raise these questions. But now, the vast reservoir of psychic optimism in India's youth demands better answers—answers that expand, instead of narrow, our political horizons. ■

“We are still using a 200-year-old model for university education. We need to prepare for a future where even a truck driver can think of doing a PhD.”

SAM PITRODA
Former chairman,
National Knowledge
Commission



Sunil Khilnani,
director of South
Asia Studies at
the Johns
Hopkins School
of Advanced
International
Studies, is the
author of *The
Idea of India*.